Introducing Philosophy

What is philosophy?

Approaches:

- “Wonder” and Philosophy
- Etymology of philosophy
- Core Branches of philosophy
- Salient features of philosophy
- Benefits of philosophy

What is wonder?

- *"the feeling of wonder is the mark of the philosopher, for all philosophy has its origins in wonder."*

  Plato(Theaetetus)
- Wonder is a state of mind, feeling, emotion of astonishment.
- It's a profound curiosity, desire to know.
- It's fundamental, foundational, basic, deep, and spontaneous.
- Wonder induces a whole range of philosophical questions.

Etymological definition

- The word philosophy was coined by Pythagoras.
- It comes from two Greek words i.e. *philien*, *philo*, *philos* meaning 'love', 'friend' and *sophia* meaning 'wisdom.'
- Thus, love of wisdom!
- 'everyone as a philosopher' vs. 'philosophy proper'
- Wisdom consists of a critical habit and eternal vigilance about all things and a reverence for truth, whatever its form, and wherever its place.

Core Branches of Philosophy

- Metaphysics
- Epistemology
- Axiology
  - Ethics
  - Aesthetics
  - Social and political philosophy
- Logic

METAPHYSICS

- Etymologically, metaphysics comes from two Greek words, *'meta'* and *'physika'* *meaning* 'after', 'beyond' and 'the natural', respectively.
- It deals with questions that take us *beyond* the material world and that cannot be reached through objective empirical study.
- It is concerned with the fundamental nature of reality and being.
- It has cosmological, ontological, anthropological, theological aspect.

EPISTEMOLOGY

- Etymologically, epistemology comes from the Greek word *'episteme'* for 'to know'
- It deals with the nature, extent, scope, method, validity, source and ground of knowledge.
- It deals with its limit and validity.
- It also deals with the distinction between justified belief and opinion.
- Epistemological theories for sources of knowledge: Empiricism, rationalism, intuitionism, skepticism, agnosticism

- **Skepticism** claims that people cannot acquire reliable knowledge and that any search for truth is in vain.
- **Agnosticism** withholds any definitive position regarding knowledge.
- **Empiricism -** knowledge can only be acquired from sensory experience. It's *a posteriori*
- **Rationalism -** knowledge is innate, natural , *a priori*
- **Intuition**- the direct apprehension of knowledge that is not derived from conscious reasoning or immediate sense perception.

AXIOLOGY: Theory of Value

- Etymology: *axios*, Greek, for 'worthy' and value from Latin *valere* meaning 'what is of worth'.
- It studies value or value- judgment in its broadest sense.
- It is normative, or prescriptive.
- We make a value judgment of society, political arrangement, objects, actions, human conduct, behavior, belief, beauty.
- One of the major issues axiology deals with is the standard or criteria based on which we value and judge.

ETHICS

- Etymologically, it is derived from the Greek word *ethikos* which itself is derived from the Greek word *ethos*, meaning "custom" or "character."
- It studies the source of moral rules, obligations, duty.
- It examines standards by which we govern our behavior, action , conduct , motive and so on.
- What makes a good action good or a bad action bad?
- What is the standard or criteria?
- *"is what is holy holy because the gods approve it, or do they approve it because it is holy?" (Plato, Euthyphro)*.

Ethical Theories :

- **Normative Ethics:**
  - Virtue ethics,
  - Deontology,
  - Consequentialism
- **Metaethics:** Cognitivism, Non-Cognitivism Relativism, Emotivism …
- **Applied Ethics:** includes Medical Ethics, Business Ethics, Professional Ethics, Environmental Ethics, Development Ethics, Ethics of Aid, Ethics of Belief and issues of abortion, euthanasia, capital punishment …

Normative ethics

- deals with the conceptual foundation and theoretical frameworks of our moral stances
- is a principle or set of principles that can be used to decide what morally ought to be done, along with the supporting reasons for such a principle.
- deals with the norms of action, in terms of whether an action is considered good or bad, right or wrong.
- It expresses values, and makes a moral judgment based on them.
- Under normative ethics the three classical types of moral theories include **Virtue Ethics**, **Deontological Ethics**, and **Consequentialism/Utilitarianism**.

Deontology

- Deontology is derived from the Greek word *'deon'* meaning 'duty'.
- In deontological ethics an action is considered morally good because of some characteristic of the action itself, not because the product of the action is good.
- It holds that at least some acts are morally obligatory regardless of their consequences for human welfare.
- It is duty-based or rule bound ethical theory.
- Its motto is: *"Let justice be done though the heaven fall!"*

Teleological/Consequentialism

- Comes from the Greek *telos*, meaning "goal-oriented".
- the morality (the rightness and wrongness) of an action, conduct, motive is determined solely by its consequences.
- Its motto is: "*The end justifies the means!*"

Virtue Ethics

- emphasizes becoming a certain sort of person , not the action of the person.
- Focuses primarily on virtue and character, rather than on duty and principles.
- Rather than seeing the heart of ethics in actions or duties, virtue ethics centers in the heart of the agent, in the character and dispositions of persons.
- Whereas action-ethics emphasize *doing*, virtue or agent ethics emphasize *being,* being a certain type of person who will no doubt manifest his or her being in actions or non-actions.
- For traditional duty-based ethics the question is: what should I do? For virtue ethics the question is: what sort of person should I become?

Meta-ethics

- "…[it is] the study of the concepts, methods of justification, and ontological assumptions of the field of ethics proper." metaethics can proceed from either an interest in the epistemology of ethics or an interest in its metaphysics. On the first approach, the study focuses on questions about the character of ethical knowledge. Typically, it concentrates on the simplest ethical beliefs, such as 'Stealing is wrong' and 'It is better to give than to receive', and proceeds by analyzing the concepts in virtue of which these beliefs are ethical and examining their logical basis. On the second approach, the study focuses on questions about the existence and character of ethical properties. Typically, it concentrates on the most general ethical predicates such as goodness and wrongfulness and considers whether there truly are ethical properties represented by these predicates and, if so, whether and how they are interwoven into the natural world." **(Cambridge Dictionary of Philosophy, 288)**

“Normative theories are first order theories about how we should behave. Moral philosophers are also interested in second order questions: these are questions not about what we ought to do but about the status of ethical theories. This theorizing about ethical theories is usually known as meta-ethics. A typical meta-ethical theory asks ‘what is the meaning of “right” in the moral context?” (Warburton, p.57)

AESTHETICS

- Etymology, '*aisthetikos'*, Greek for 'to perceive' 'perceptible things'
- What is beauty?
- Socrates – "what makes beautiful things beautiful?"
- What kinds of things do or should count as art?

Political and Social philosophy

- What is the just society?
- On what basis, if any, can society compel us to obey its rules if we don't wish to obey them? Where does its source of authority originate from?
- How best can we live together? (For example, Aristotle formulated 130+ constitutions).
- What do we owe each other?

LOGIC

- Etymologically, it comes from '*logos',* Greek, for speech, word, reason.
- It is the study of the method, form, principle, and rule of argument, reasoning or inference.
- It studies standards that differentiate good reasoning from bad reasoning.

Salient Features of Philosophy

Mode of Thought	*Science*	Philosophy	Religion
Method	Laboratory-based observation and experiment	Reasoning + Logic	Faith+ Revelation (fideism)
Scope and Nature	Physical	Metaphysical	Metaphysical
	Empirical reality	Ultimate reality	Ultimate reality
	"is"	"ought"	"ought"

- Philosophical reasoning as a method
- It critically questions everything, primarily our most entrenched assumptions, and deeply held beliefs. So, no presumption! *ኩሉ አመክሩ ወዘሰናየ አጽንኡ!*
- It deals with fundamental philosophical problems or most general and universal questions.

- It has no clearly defined subject matter. It pursues issues wherever they are raised.
- It's a quest for consistent whole and worldview.
- It is an activity of reasoning, questioning, critical thinking, analysis, (of language and clarification of concepts) conceptualization, and a perpetual engagement in a thought experiment.

Importance of Philosophy

- Creativity and Imagination

"To invent you need a good imagination"-
Thomas Edison.

- Independence –*Is your mind truly yours?*
- Open-mindedness, tolerance, flexibility, humility –*How open and tolerant are you to different ideas?*
- Critical thinker(But what if…?) vs. being conformist
- higher-level needs/actualizing needs Vs. maintenance needs *Have you reached your full potential?*